Renewing the Long Experiment

A National Campaign for Experiential Civic Education

The Problem

American democracy depends on citizens who know how to cooperate, serve, and lead. That capacity is declining. Civic participation is at historic lows. Social trust is eroding. A generation is entering adulthood without the practiced habits of self-government.

The Solution

The National Experiential Civic Education Framework (NECEF) embeds structured, hands-on civic programs in schools nationwide — giving students real practice in the habits democracy requires.

Four Core Pillars

- Community Service Projects
- Emergency Preparedness Training
- Infrastructure and Community Stewardship
- Leadership Rotations

Historical Grounding

The Founders knew democracy required practiced citizens. The Constitution placed sovereignty in 'We the People.' Madison insisted civic virtue could not be replaced by institutional design alone. Tocqueville identified civic association as the engine of American democratic vitality. Putnam proved the data: where civic engagement falls, democratic health follows.

Who Needs to Act

- Federal policymakers — Framework legislation
- Governors — State adoption
- Philanthropists — Pilot co-funding
- Civic organizations — Program delivery
- Business leaders — Workforce advocacy

The republic was always a wager on the capability of its citizens. Every generation must choose to tend it.

References: U.S. Constitution (1787) | The Federalist Papers (1788) | Tocqueville, Democracy in America (1835) | Putnam, Bowling Alone (2000)